



◁ MUDDY WATERS

The silt-laden Yellow River flows through deep gorges before it descends onto the North China Plain.

CHANGING COURSES

The Yellow River has changed course many times over the centuries, sometimes as the result of human activity. It moved 26 times and flooded nearly 1,600 times between 602 BCE and 1938 CE, resulting in the loss of millions of lives.



KEY

- Current channel
- Former channel
- Former shoreline

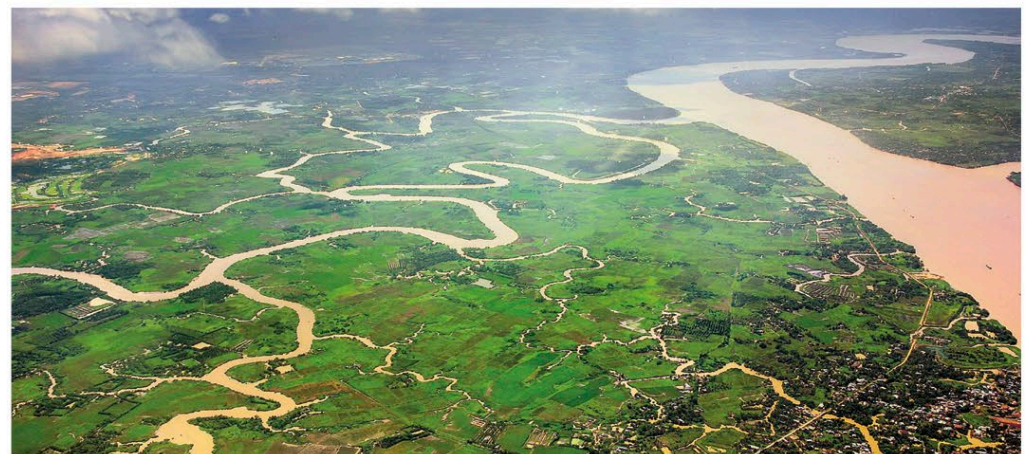


SE. Asia

The Mekong

Southeast Asia's greatest river system, passing through six different countries

Like the Yellow River and the Yangtze, the Mekong has its source on the Tibetan Plateau. It runs in a southeast direction through western China, Myanmar, Laos, Thailand, Cambodia, and Vietnam, crossing some national borders and forming others. At its mouth, in the South China Sea, it forms a delta just south of Ho Chi Minh City. With a length of about 2,700 miles (4,350 km), the Mekong is the longest river in Southeast Asia. The very long river basin includes many climatic zones and a diverse range of habitats including upland plateaus, forests, savannas, grasslands, wetlands, and mangroves. As a result, it is an area of extremely high biodiversity.



△ DELTA FLOODPLAINS

This aerial view shows part of the huge Mekong Delta in southern Vietnam. The flat floodplains in the south contrast with the hilly areas in other parts of the delta.

▷ MEKONG GIANT

The Mekong is home to many large fish species. The giant freshwater stingray can be over 16 ft (5 m) long and 6 ft (2 m) wide, and has the longest stinging spine of any stingray.

stinging spine
used in defense

